



Shaping Tomorrow

As SAP Labs India becomes central to the firm's global AI engine, Sindhu Gangadharan leads with agility, purpose, and a focus on transforming India into a creator of deep tech

BY PALAK AGARWAL



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WITH HER WARM, composed demeanour and ever-present, disarming smile, Sindhu Gangadharan—one of India's most influential tech leaders and the Managing Director of SAP Labs India—stands out as a commanding yet approachable force in the industry.

For Gangadharan, technology has always been a natural extension of her curiosity. And her ascent reflects that clarity of purpose. In August 2024, she took over as the Chairperson of Nasscom, the apex body representing India's \$245-billion technology industry.

Talking to *BT* about her journey, Gangadharan says, "Curiosity shaped my early years—I was always drawn to how systems worked and why people made certain choices. That instinct naturally led me towards problem-solving roles and, eventually, to engineering."

Under Gangadharan's leadership, SAP Labs India opened its second campus in Bengaluru, its largest R&D hub outside Germany, with an investment of €194 million. She says SAP Labs India has grown into a cornerstone of the firm's global innovation engine. The work that happens here influences products, platforms, and customer experiences across every region.

India has emerged as a pivotal hub in shaping SAP's Artificial Intelligence (AI) road map. It plays a central

role in the content strategy, execution, and onboarding for Joule, SAP's AI copilot—directly supporting global priorities and enhancing how customers adopt AI across business processes. "Over 70% to 80% of agents are created in India," says Gangadharan.

Highlighting India's broader global contribution, she notes that the AI core experience layer is built in India. The India team also leads the development of an AI-based reporting assistant for ESG, a product gaining significant traction among customers focusing on responsible business practices.

"We also announced Business Data Cloud this year—a fully managed software-as-a-service solution that unifies and governs all SAP data and integrates with third-party data to provide actionable intelligence," Gangadharan says.

How is Gangadharan navigating the AI-led transformation? She believes leadership is tested most when the world moves unpredictably—and the past few years have brought rapid growth, shifting skill demands.

"When I returned to India to lead SAP Labs India, I anchored every decision in a simple belief: put people at the centre," she says. During periods of change, teams look for clarity and reassurance, and she focused on providing both through open communication, empathy, and a steady, future-facing vision. Conversations with leaders across SAP reinforced one truth for her: agility now defines modern leadership.

Asked what India must prioritise to remain globally competitive, she is unequivocal: the country needs to accelerate its shift from execution to creation. That means nurturing stronger patent cultures, encouraging young engineers to think beyond implementation, and equipping them with the skills and clarity required to build long-term IP.

"Customer expectations in APAC continue to rise. They want technology that delivers speed, trust, and measurable outcomes. They're looking for partners who can combine deep product capability with regional context—especially as they scale up GenAI across manufacturing, retail, logistics, financial services, and the public sector," she says.

And in an AI era moving at the speed of light, what keeps her anchored outside of work? "Mornings of yoga, time with family and my furry friend Dexter, honest conversations, quiet walks, and baking form the rhythm that keeps me grounded, energised, and centred each day," she says. **BT**

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